Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <filen>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

`v3wd`	– enter select mode, select 3 words, delete

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

`.`	– any character
`*`	– zero or more
`+`	– one or more
`?`	– zero or one / lazy match
`^`	– start of line / negation in class
`$`	– end of line
`( )`	– capture group
`[ ]`	– character class
`{ }`	– repetition count
`|`	– alternation
`\`	– escape character itself

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

`u / U`	– undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	– move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	– move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	– repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	– return to normal mode

2.3.2 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	– write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	– write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	– write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	– quit current buffer, exits if last

2.3.3 Files

`:o <file>`	– open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	– write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	– open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	– open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	– open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	– open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	– open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	– open changed file picker

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	– open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	– open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	– open selected in new vertical split

2.3.4 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	– create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	– close current buffer
`:bca`	– close all buffers
`:bco`	– close all but current buffer
`:bn`	– next buffer
`␣b`	– open buffer picker
`ga`	– go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	– go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	– go to next buffer
`gp`	– go to previous buffer

2.3.5 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	– split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	– split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	– close current split
`␣wo`	– close all but current split
`␣ww`	– next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	– move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	– swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	– transpose split

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	– enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	– align to center
`zt`	– align to top
`zb`	– align to bottom
`zm`	– align to middle horizontally
`zj`	– scroll down
`zk`	– scroll up

2.3.6 Help

`:tutor`	– open tutorial
`␣?`	– open command palette

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

`h/j/k/l`	– left / up / down / right
`gh, g|`	– beginning of line
`<nn>g|`	– column <nn>
`gl`	– end of line
`gg`	– top of file
`<nn>G, g<nn>g`	– line <nn>
`ge`	– bottom of file
`gw`	– two-char labels on words, label to go to word
`g.`	– to last modification in current file
`gj`	– down textual line
`gk`	– up textual line
`gs`	– first non-white-space char
`gt`	– top of screen
`gc`	– middle of screen
`gb`	– bottom of screen

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

`gd`	– go to definition
`gy`	– go to type definition
`gr`	– go to references
`gi`	– go to implementation
`]d`	– next diagnostic
`[d`	– prior diagnostic
`]D`	– last diagnostic
`[D`	– first diagnostic

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

`]f, [f`	– to next, prior function
`]t, [t`	– to next, prior type definition
`]T, [T`	– to next, prior test
`]a, [a`	– to next, prior arg
`]c, [c`	– to next, prior comment
`]g, [g`	– to next, prior change
`]G, [G`	– to last, first change
`Alt-e`	– move to end of parent node in syntax tree
`Alt-b`	– move to start of parent node in syntax tree

2.4.4 By Page

`Ctrl-b`	– page up
`Ctrl-f`	– page down
`Ctrl-u`	– half page up
`Ctrl-d`	– half page down

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

`%`	– select whole file
`Alt-;`	– swap anchor and cursor
`Alt-:`	– selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
`Alt-o`	– expand selection syntax-aware
`Alt-i`	– shrink selection
`;`	– collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)

2.5.2 By TextObjects

`ma<ch> / mi<ch>`	– match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below:
`w / W`	– word / WORD
`p`	– paragraph
`(, [, ', etc.`	– specified surround pairs
`m`	– closest surround pair
`f`	– function
`t`	– type or class
`a`	– argument/parameter
`c`	– comment
`T`	– test
`g`	– change git hunk

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

`w / W`	– to start of next word / WORD
`e / E`	– to end of current word / WORD
`b / B`	– to start of current word / WORD
`x`	– current line, extend by line
`X`	– extend to line
`Alt-x`	– shrink to line bounds
`]p`	– to next paragraph
`[p`	– to prior paragraph

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

`Alt-o`	– expand selection to parent syntax node
`Alt-i`	– shrink syntax tree object selection
`Alt-p`	– select previous sibling node in syntax tree
`Alt-n`	– select next sibling node in syntax tree
`Alt-a`	– select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
`Alt-I`	– select all children nodes in syntax tree

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

`f<ch>, F<ch>`	– to <ch> inclusive (find)
`t<ch>, T<ch>`	– to <ch> exclusive (till)
`Alt-.`	– repeat last find / till

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

`v`	– toggle select mode
`Esc`	– return to normal
`)`	– cycle primary selection forward
`(`	– cycle primary selection backward
`Alt-,`	– remove primary selection

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	– matches become selections
`S`	– split on match
`Alt-s`	– split on newlines
`C / Alt-C`	– add selection below / above

2.7.2 Operations

`&`	– align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	– merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	– merge consecutive selections
`,`	– remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	– remove primary selection
`( / )`	– rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	– rotate content backward / forward
`K`	– keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	– remove selections matching the regex

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

`i`	– before selection
`a`	– after selection
`I`	– at start of line
`A`	– at end of line
`o`	– add line and insert below cursor
`O`	– add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	– end insert (return to normal)
`.`	– repeat last insert

2.8.2 Add

`]␣`	– newline below
`[␣`	– newline above
`ms<ch>`	– add delim <ch> around selection

2.8.3 Delete

`d`	– selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	– delete, no save
`md<ch>`	– delete delim <ch> around selection

2.8.4 Change

`c`	– selection -> yank buf, change selection
`Alt-c`	– change, no save
`=`	– format by LSP
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	– replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.8.5 Indent Lines

`>`	– Indent line(s) containing selection
`<`	– Undent line(s) containing selection

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

`~`	– change case
`` ` ``	– set lowercase
`Alt-` `	– set uppercase

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

`␣c, Ctrl-c`	– Toggle comment
`␣C`	– Toggle block comment
`␣Alt-C`	– Toggle line comment

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

`Ctrl-a`	– increment the selected number
`Ctrl-x`	– decrement the selected number

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

`J`	– join lines in a selection
`Alt-J`	– join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
`<under>`	– trim whitespace from selection
`:reflow <width>`	– wrap selection to <width>, default 80
`:sort`	– sort ranges in selection
`:format`	– format file using external formatter / language server

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

`y`	– selection -> yank buf
`p`	– paste yank buf after the cursor
`P`	– paste yank buf before the cursor
`␣y`	– yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
`␣Y`	– yank main selection -> system clipboard
`␣p / ␣P`	– paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
`␣R`	– replace selection(s) with clipboard
`r<ch>`	– replace selection with <ch>
`R`	– replace selection with yank buf
`"`	– select register to yank to or paste from

2.10 Search

`/<regex>`	– search forward for regex
`?<regex>`	– search backward for regex
`n, N`	– next, previous match
`*`	– search for current selection, respect word boundaries
`Alt-*`	– search for current selection

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

`"<ch>`	– change to reg <ch>
`"<ch>y`	– yank into reg <ch>
`"<ch>p`	– paste from reg <ch>
`"<ch>R`	– replace with reg <ch>

2.12 Macros

`"<ch>Q`	– toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
`"<ch>q`	– play macro in reg <ch>, default @

2.13 Jumplists

`Ctrl-s`	– save current position to jumplist
`Ctrl-i`	– move forward in jumplist
`Ctrl-o`	– move backwards in jumplist
`␣j`	– open jumplist picker

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

`mm`	– go to matching delim
`mi<ch>`	– match inside delim <ch>
`ma<ch>`	– match around delim <ch>
`ms<ch>`	– add delim <ch> around selection
`md<ch>`	– delete delim <ch> around selection
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	– replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

`|`	– replace selection(s) with output
`Alt-|`	– ignore output
`!`	– insert output before each selection(s)
`Alt-!`	– append output after each selection(s)
`$`	– keep selection(s) where command returned 0

2.16 Approaching an IDE

`␣G`	– debug - experimental
`␣k`	– show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s`	– open document symbol picker
`␣S`	– open workspace symbol picker
`␣d`	– open document diagnostics picker
`␣D`	– open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r`	– rename symbol
`␣a`	– apply code action
`␣h`	– select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.17 Editor Configuration

`:config-open`	– open the config file
`:config-open-workspace`	– open the workspace config file
`:config-reload`	– reload the config file

2.18 Miscellaneous

`␣'`	– open last picker
`␣/`	– open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	– commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	– autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	– insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	– delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	– insert new line
`<Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>, <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>`	– usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	– close prompt
`<enter>`	– open selected
`<tab>`	– select next completion item
`<backtab>`	– select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	– backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	– backward a char
`Alt-f`	– forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	– forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	– to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	– to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	– delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	– delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	– delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	– delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	– delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	– delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	– insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	– select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	– select next history
`Ctrl-r`	– insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>`	– previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>`	– next entry
`<Home>`	– to first entry
`<End>`	– to last entry
`Ctrl-u, <PageUp>`	– page up
`Ctrl-d, <PageDown>`	– page down
`<enter>`	– open selected
`Alt-<enter>`	– open selected in the background without closing the picker
`Ctrl-s`	– open horizontally
`Ctrl-v`	– open vertically
`Ctrl-t`	– toggle preview
`Esc, Ctrl-c`	– close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

`Ctrl-u`	– scroll up
`Ctrl-d`	– scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

`Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p`	– previous entry
`Tab, Ctrl-n`	– next entry
`<enter>`	– close menu and accept completion
`Ctrl-c`	– close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

`Alt-p`	– previous signature
`Alt-n`	– next signature